



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Amarillo Collegiate Academy: Main Campus

School Website: <https://responsived.com/campus/amarillo-collegiate-academy/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Amarillo Collegiate Academy Main Campus (Amarillo, TX 79118) demonstrates a consciously formation-focused orientation that aligns with several classical education principles, but it stops short of full classical implementation in several key areas. The public-facing materials emphasize character formation, virtue, and the aim of producing virtuous, responsible citizens, along with a time-tested, Core Knowledge–tinged curriculum and individualized, mastery-style progression. However, explicit commitments to core classical pillars (e.g., Great Books to join the Great Conversation, robust use of the trivium/quadrivium, Socratic pedagogy, a living-curriculum model, liturgical or explicit theological foundations, and a fully engaged parent partnership as co-educators) are not clearly articulated on the school's site. Taken together, the school appears to inhabit a space that is “Somewhat Classical,” with notable strengths in formation and ethical aims but with clear gaps in classic liturgical/theological grounding, Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, and a full classical pedagogy.

Key insights: - Strengths in formation and virtue: The site foregrounds character formation, virtue, and citizenship as central aims, with explicit statements about virtues and a three-fold educational purpose (citizenship, virtue, and liberty) that point toward a classical telos. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for categories centered on purpose and formation. - Curriculum signals with classical flavor but not full classical rigor: The site references a Core Knowledge framework and a strong curriculum, but does not demonstrate explicit Great Books engagement, Trivium/Quadrivium emphasis, or classic memorization/recitation practices. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categorization for curriculum and pedagogy. - Pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community signals: Public materials emphasize a modern, personalized, and teacher-centered approach with dedicated faculty, but there is limited indication of Socratic seminars, scholé/restful learning, or a living-curriculum model, and minimal explicit parent co-teaching or liturgical/community practices. These favor a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL assessment rather than CLASSICAL out and out.

Overall aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school site foregrounds formation of character and virtue as central aims, including language about shaping the heart and cultivating virtuous citizens. While not framed as theology, the emphasis on virtue and character aligns with transcendent aims rather than purely secular skills. Example: “Formation of Character” header and the statement that “the shaping of a student’s heart is more important than the shaping of their mind.” and “to help children develop into responsible citizens, to help them learn to be virtuous people.” - The materials do not reference liturgy, sacred rituals, or explicit doctrinal/theological grounding, nor do they present a liturgical or ceremonial program on the public site.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, character, formation (positive category indicators for the category’s lexicon around formation and virtue). The text directly uses “Formation of Character” and “virtuous people.” - Negative keywords present: none clearly evident (no explicit secularism/relativism signals in the public-facing text). However, the absence of theology, liturgy, or explicit transcendent theism is notable.

Why this rating - The content demonstrates a focus on transcendent aims (virtue/character), but it does not explicitly articulate theological grounding, liturgical practice, or a theologically anchored foundation. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating: partial alignment with classical moral formation, but lacking explicit theological and liturgical anchors.

What would move the needle - Add explicit statements of theological grounding or liturgical practices (even if ecumenical) and reference to “truth, goodness, and beauty” as real, knowable ideals to push toward CLASSICAL in this category. - Include explicit statements about liturgical year, communal worship, or sacred music to align with liturgical/community practice signals.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe formation goals oriented toward citizenship, virtue, and liberty—“to help children develop into responsible citizens, to help them learn to be virtuous people, and to promote a free society.” These aim beyond mere information transfer and emphasize a humane telos. - The messaging asserts formation and virtue as core aims, with a sense of flourishing humans as an outcome. There is a stated commitment to mastery and personal growth, and to a “time-tested information” approach merged with modern methods. - Great Books/Great Conversation is not explicitly claimed; the curriculum is described as Core Knowledge with a high-quality curriculum rather than a Great Books library or paideia framework. This points to a classical orientation in aims but not in the explicit method.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, telos (implicit), great conversation (not present; see below), wisdom (not explicitly stated, though implied via virtue and formation), classical mission (not claimed, but “formation” and “virtue” signals alignment with classical aims). The visible terms include “formation,” “virtue,” “citizens,” and “flourishing humans.” - Negative keywords present: absence of explicit “Great Books,” “Great Conversation,” or direct references to Trivium/Quadrivium or scholé, and no explicit theological grounding. The absence of a formal Great Books program and explicit telos terms beyond virtue suggests a partial classical alignment.

Why this rating - The school centers formation and virtue as core objectives and frames education as a formation process with a humane telos, which aligns with classical aims more than with a modern, purely career-focused curriculum. However, the lack of explicit Great Books engagement, rhetorical training, or theological grounding keeps Element 2 from a CLASSICAL rating and places it at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Explicitly articulate a Great Books/Great Conversation component and a clear rationale for liberal-arts formation (grammar, logic, rhetoric, philosophy, history) as foundational goals. - State a more explicit telos linked to truth, goodness, and beauty, and tie formation to contemplative study practices (Scholé) to move toward CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site notes the use of a Core Knowledge framework and a “strong curriculum” designed to meet expectations, which signals a structured, content-rich program rather than purely skills-based training. This signals a classical orientation in curriculum philosophy, albeit not necessarily in content or method. - There is no explicit mention of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; trivium/quadrivium) or a persistent Great Books or Western-civilizational canon. The explicit emphasis appears to be on a publicly accessible, modern curriculum with a Core Knowledge approach rather than a fully classical canon. - There is mention of “three-fold” aims and personal ownership of learning, consistent with mastery and formation, but the absence of Great Books and explicit classical content signals only partial classical alignment.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation (via the focus on forming citizens and virtue), virtue, core knowledge framework (a structured curriculum approach, though not the classical Core Knowledge of the 20th century alone), and “strong curriculum.” These are indicative of a rigorous

program but not necessarily classical content. - Negative keywords present: lack of Great Books, lack of explicit Trivium/Quadrivium, lack of history-as-history (as opposed to social studies within the modern curriculum). The absence of liberal-arts content in the public materials aligns with a NOT full classical.

Why this rating - The curriculum signals a rigorous, modern instructional approach with an emphasis on mastery and a “Core Knowledge” framework rather than explicit classical content (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, or direct history through a classical lens). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating: it leans classical in aims and structure (with our positive signals around formation and a strong curriculum) but lacks core explicit classical curriculum commitments.

What would move the needle - Publicly commit to Great Books and the Great Conversation, explicit incorporation of the Trivium/Quadrivium as a framework for grammar, logic, rhetoric, and the mathematical/harmonic sciences, and explicit history as Western civilization history within the curriculum. - Include explicit instructions on how history, literature, philosophy, and sciences are integrated (interdisciplinary/harmonious approach) and emphasize wonder as a curricular outcome.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize a modern, personalized instruction approach and blended learning, with a focus on mastery and self-directed progression. There is no explicit mention of Socratic dialogue, scholé, memory work, chanting, or formal memorization/dictation practices that characterize classical pedagogy. - The material highlights that students “master their coursework” and work with personalized instruction, but it does not describe Socratic seminars, Harkness discussions, or a rhetoric-training pathway, which are central to classical pedagogy. - The lack of explicit upper-school rhetoric/thesis work, or structured Socratic, ritualized memory/recitation, or formal classical demonstration of mastery signals a non-classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: recitation/memory work, chanting, and Scholé are not present. The Positive Keywords list for Pedagogy includes Socratic dialogue, scholé, memorization/recitation, and formation through imitation. The site does not show these practices; thus there is a lack of classical pedagogy signals. - Negative keywords present: experiential learning and student-directed, constructivist approaches are listed as negative indicators for classical pedagogy in the lexicon; the site’s emphasis on personalized instruction and mastery rather than Socratic or memory-based pedagogy aligns with those non-classical signals.

Why this rating - The absence of explicit Socratic discussions, scholé practices, regular memorization/recitation, or other classical pedagogy signals leads to a NOT CLASSICAL designation for pedagogy. The school’s public materials describe a modern, individualized approach rather than a classical, inquiry-based, or rhetorically focused pedagogy.

What would move the needle - Introduce a formal classical pedagogy: implement regular Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars (especially in upper grades), memory work and recitation (including chants/memorization in lower grades), and a clear plan for the development of rhetoric and public speaking (oratory and declamation) in upper grades. - Include explicit Scholé days, contemplative study times, and restful learning rhythms in the schedule to align with the classical concept of scholé.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Materials emphasize “dedicated staff” and “Caring Teachers,” indicating a commitment to skilled, supportive faculty. Public-facing statements describe teachers as open to new ideas and flexible to student needs. - The school presents faculty as a core element of the school’s educational experience, though there is no explicit “living curriculum” or teacher portrait/culture description. The public materials highlight the faculty’s role in forming citizens and virtues but do not detail a formal classical faculty profile.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: dedicated staff, caring teachers, teachers open to new ideas, and a focus on faculty as the vehicle for forming citizens. These align with the classical faculty concept of mentors and living exemplars to guide formation (though not explicitly described as “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher”). - Negative keywords present: not explicitly shown in the site text; however, there is no explicit characterization of faculty as “masters” or “virtue models” or “living curriculum.” The absence of such descriptors reduces the strength of a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Why this rating - The presence of dedicated, caring teachers supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, but the lack of a deeper “living curriculum” portrayal or explicit classical faculty portraits reduces it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The evidence indicates strong teacher quality and partnership with students but not the full classical faculty ethos.

What would move the needle - Articulate a formal classical faculty framework: a defined portrait of a teacher, formal mentorship models, ongoing professional development in classical pedagogy, and a visible “living curriculum” approach in which teachers embody and model classical aims.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site’s public materials do not prominently present an explicit partnership model with parents as co-teachers, nor do they describe formal parent formation, book studies, or frequent parent visits. The emphasis is on student-centered, personalized instruction with the school as the primary educator. - There is no explicit mention of parent formation programs, classical parent training, or regular open-campus events in the public materials, which are typical signals of classical parent-community engagement.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: parent partnership, family involvement, parent formation, and classical family culture signals appear in the classical lexicon but are not evidenced on the Amarillo site. The school’s materials do not demonstrate these signals. Consequently, the presence of positive keywords is minimal or absent on the public site. - Negative keywords present: absence of family-formation language, parent-co-teacher partnership, and open-campus language. The lack of parental engagement signals yields a NOT CLASSICAL designation for this category.

Why this rating - The school does not clearly demonstrate the classical parent/community partnership signals (co-teachers, formation of families, and open access to visits) in its public materials, which aligns with a NOT CLASSICAL designation for this category.

What would move the needle - Publicly commit to a formal parent-co-teacher partnership, provide parent formation opportunities (book studies, lectures, seminars on classical education, etc.), and invite open visits for families to engage with the school’s classical aims and methods.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit language tying character formation to transcendent ideals (truth, goodness, beauty) and, if appropriate, liturgical/community practices.
- For Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): Tie formation more explicitly to a classical telos by articulating a deeper liberal-arts formation (including Great Books or canonical texts) and clearly linking virtue with intellectual development (wisdom).
- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Adopt a stated commitment to Great Books/Great Conversation and provide a detailed plan for incorporating Trivium/Quadrivium elements and the history of Western civilization into the curriculum.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Introduce classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogue or Paideia-style seminars, memory work, recitation, and cyclical Scholé days) and articulate a timeline for gradual integration.

- For Element 5 (Faculty): Develop a formal “living curriculum” portrait of the teacher and a professional development plan in classical pedagogy to strengthen the classical faculty identity.
 - For Element 6 (Parents & Community): Create robust parent-partner programs (co-teaching language, parent formation, classical book clubs, campus visits) to elevate parent engagement.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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